in peacetime for Border Management Posture (BMP) duties, which had earlier been the exclusive preserve of 5 Mtn Div.[1]

Veena and Isha also came to Phulbari whenever possible. On one such visit, I was sitting at home, my *kutir*, doing some calculations involving mule loads. Anyone who has remotely been near mules would know how vexing these problems are. Domestic load and useful load, turnaround distances, speeds uphill and downhill. No matter how hard one tried, the figures would never tally. While I was doing this, Isha, who was reading something, was chuckling away in a corner. When I asked her, she said she was reading a book about the British in Afghanistan and the problems they had with recalcitrant mules. I asked for the book and checked what period it pertained to and discerned that it was of the period between 1839 and 1842. When I told her I was solving mule-related problems, she could not believe her ears, giving me a hearty laugh and a disbelieving look. That set me thinking that we don't seem to have changed much in more than 150 years. Surely there was a better way of doing things?

Slowly and steadily, things started taking shape. The administrative team under Col Makol had done a terrific job of collecting all the controlled stores and equipment from depots all over the country. We soon realized that the difficult part of the raising was not of the HQ itself, but of all the other institutions that go to make up an organization. The unit-run canteen (URC) is a case in point. Not only did we have to apply to open a URC but also secure a loan as the starting capital. A building had to be identified and civil works carried out to make it functional. Racks and counters had to be procured for displaying the goods. So many things that we had taken for granted, not knowing how the back-end really functions or the effort that it had taken to reach that stage. There was a small

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